

LIBERTY SEVERS

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PROFILE

Philosopher and cognitive scientist working on the topic of agency. My research takes a theoretical and experimental approach to the comparative problem of agency, with a focus on the comparative scope of reinforcement learning as a framework for operationalising agency and how constraints and divergent evolutionary histories shape the control processes that enable agential behaviour across species.

CURRENT POSITIONS

Writing-up Fellow — Konrad Lorenz Institute for Evolution and Cognition Research, Vienna Oct 2025 – present
Co-Founder & Research Lead — Non-Neural Cognition Lab Dec 2024 – present
PhD Researcher / Visiting Fellow — University of Lisbon & Ruhr-Universität Bochum Jan 2023 – present

EDUCATION

PhD, History and Philosophy of Science — University of Lisbon 2023 – 2026 (expected)
Dissertation: *Reinforcement learning and the organisation of agency: a constraint-theoretic account*
Supervisors: Dr Davide Vecchi (UNED), Dr Inês Hipólito (Macquarie), Prof Pedro Freitas (Lisbon)
MSc, Cognitive Neuroscience — University of Sussex 2019 – 2021
MA, Philosophy of Mind & Cognitive Science — University of Birmingham 2017 – 2018
BA (Hons), Philosophy — Heythrop College, University of London 2014 – 2017

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

- Writing-up Fellowship, Konrad Lorenz Institute (2025 – present)
- Visiting Fellowship, RUB Institute for Philosophy II — funded by the Volkswagen Foundation (2024 – present)
- International Research Exchange Scholarship, Ruhr University Bochum Research School (2024)
- Doctoral Fellowship, Centre for the Philosophy of Science, University of Lisbon (2023)

PUBLICATIONS

- Severs, L. & Wang, Q. (2025). Continual decision-making dynamics across biological organisms. *Biological Reviews*.
- Becattini, V., & Severs, L. (2025). Are ambient smart environments sufficient for developing good habits? *Synthese*, 206, 5.
- Parvizi-Wayne, D. & Severs, L. (2024). When the interoceptive and the conceptual clash: The case of oppositional self-modelling in Tourette Syndrome. *Cognitive, Affective, & Behavioral Neuroscience*, 24, 660–680.
- Broulidakis, M. J., Severs, L., et al. (2023). Optomyography-based sensing of facial expression derived arousal and valence in adults with depression. *Frontiers in Psychiatry*, 14.

SELECTED TALKS

- *Physarum polycephalum as a model organism for heterarchical control* — Philosophy of Science Association, San Diego (forthcoming).
- *Beyond control: Reinforcement learning and the operational foundations of agency* — KLI Fall Symposium, Vienna (Nov 2025).
- *Organisation before representation: how control structures support adaptive strategies for learning and decision-making* — ISPSM Annual Meeting (Oct 2025).

- *From local feedback to global goals: learning and decision-making in the acellular slime mould* — RLDM, Dublin (Jun 2025).
- *An active inference account of self-modelling in Tourette syndrome* — Theoretical Biology Seminar, University College London (Jan 2024).

ORGANISATIONAL & EDITORIAL ROLES

Vice President — International Society for the Philosophy of the Sciences of the Mind	2025 – <i>present</i>
Co-Founder & Research Lead — Non-Neural Cognition Lab	2024 – <i>present</i>
Programme Chair — International Society for the Philosophy of the Sciences of the Mind	2023 – 2024
Organiser — 3rd Int'l Conference for the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence, University of the Azores	2024